

Notes: Ekmekci & Lauermann (RES, 2020)

Manipulated Electorates and Information Aggregation

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1 Big picture

- **Question.** Can elections reliably aggregate dispersed information when the number of participating voters depends on the state of the world?
- **Benchmark.** Standard Condorcet-jury logic says that large elections aggregate information: if many voters each receive noisy signals, majority rule selects the correct policy with probability close to one.
- **Central disruption.** That conclusion relies on the number of voters being state independent. When turnout differs across states, the event of being pivotal is more likely in the low-turnout state, so pivotality itself becomes an informative event.
- **Main theoretical result.** If turnout is asymmetric across states, large elections have additional symmetric responsive equilibria in which information aggregation fails. The policy favored in the low-turnout state can win in both states.
- **Manipulation channel.** A biased informed organizer can recruit voters in a state-dependent way. If the organizer prefers policy a regardless of the state, he can induce expectations of lower turnout in state α , making policy a win with high probability even in state β .
- **Endogenous participation result.** When voter recruitment is costly but the cost becomes small, there are equilibria in which the organizer recruits many voters in both states, recruits more in β than in α , and implements policy a with probability converging to one in both states.
- **Robustness.** The logic extends to Poisson electorates, voluntary voting, small aggregate uncertainty, and noisy public signals about election size; election design or competing organizers can weaken but not eliminate all concerns.
- **Economic takeaway.** Large electorates do not automatically solve information problems. If turnout is state-dependent, the size of the electorate becomes part of the information environment and can itself distort aggregation.

2 Incremental contribution

- **Relative to Feddersen and Pesendorfer.** The paper identifies a hidden assumption behind large-election information aggregation: turnout must not convey state information through pivotality. The contribution is not to reject the Condorcet logic entirely, but to show exactly when it breaks.
- **Relative to uncertain-population voting models.** Prior work such as Myerson shows existence of information-aggregating equilibria under random electorates. Ekmekci and Lauermann focus on the full equilibrium set and show that nonaggregating equilibria also exist whenever participation is state-dependent.
- **Relative to turnout-manipulation stories.** The paper gives a fully strategic model in which a biased organizer endogenously chooses turnout after observing the state and without committing publicly to a turnout policy.
- **Relative to persuasion or information-control models.** The organizer does not directly change voters' signals or preferences. He manipulates only the number of people asked to vote, which is often a more subtle and realistic instrument.
- **New mechanism.** The key object is the *participation curse*: being pivotal is more likely in the state with fewer voters, so the pivotal voter should overweight the low-turnout state.
- **Policy contribution.** The paper explains why turnout rules, quorum requirements, near-unanimity rules, and competition between biased organizers can matter for information aggregation, not merely for participation levels.

How to remember the contribution. The paper turns turnout from a passive sample-size variable into an endogenous signal. Once turnout can depend on the state, the standard “more voters means better aggregation” intuition is incomplete.

3 Model primitives and measurement

3.1 States, policies, and voter preferences

- There are two states, α and β , and two policies, a and b .
- Voters have common interests: policy a is correct in state α , and policy b is correct in state β .
- The prior probability of state α is ρ .
- Voters are symmetric ex ante and receive private signals $s \in [0, 1]$.
- The signal density satisfies a monotone likelihood ratio property, so lower signals favor α and higher signals favor β .

Interpretation: The model isolates information aggregation rather than distributive conflict among voters. Voters want the correct policy; failure comes from equilibrium inference, not disagreement over objectives.

3.2 Organizer and recruitment technology

- The organizer observes the true state before choosing how many voters to recruit.
- The organizer is biased: he always prefers policy a , no matter which state is true.
- If the organizer recruits n pairs of voters, total turnout is $2n + 1$, which avoids ties.
- Each additional pair costs c .
- The organizer's payoff is $1 - cn$ if policy a wins and $-cn$ if policy b wins.
- Voters observe their signals but do not observe realized turnout.

Interpretation: The organizer's instrument is not vote buying or signal manipulation. It is selective mobilization. This makes the mechanism relevant for shareholder votes, political mobilization, timing/location choices, and committee agenda control.

3.3 Voting strategies and cutoffs

- A pure voter strategy maps private signals into a vote for a or b .
- Equilibria have cutoff form: vote for a below a signal cutoff and for b above it.
- Let $q_\omega(d)$ be the expected share of votes for a in state ω .
- A voter conditions on three events: receiving signal s , being recruited, and being pivotal.

Interpretation: The pivotal event is crucial. Voting is a low-probability decision, so the conditional probability of the state given that the vote matters can differ sharply from the unconditional posterior.

3.4 Information aggregation

- An election aggregates information if the majority chooses a in α and b in β with probability converging to one as the electorate becomes large.
- Information aggregation can fail in two ways: policy a wins in both states or policy b wins in both states.
- In the manipulated equilibria of the paper, the organizer's preferred policy a wins in both states.

Interpretation: The paper’s main concern is not random error in finite elections. It is systematic asymptotic failure even when elections are large.

4 Theoretical specifications and equilibrium conditions

4.1 Expected vote share

$$q_\omega(d) = \Pr(d(s) = a \mid \omega) = \int_{s \in [0,1]} \mathbf{1}_{d(s)=a} f(s \mid \omega) ds.$$

Interpretation: The expected vote share summarizes the voting strategy in each state. If q_α and q_β are both above one half, policy a wins in both states in a large election.

4.2 Pivot probability

$$\Pr(\text{pivotal in state } \omega) = \binom{2n_\omega}{n_\omega} q_\omega^{n_\omega} (1 - q_\omega)^{n_\omega}.$$

Interpretation: Pivotality decays faster in the state with more voters. This is the mathematical source of the participation curse.

4.3 Critical likelihood ratio

$$\Phi(s, \text{piv}, \text{rec}; n, d) = \text{prior} \times \text{signal likelihood ratio} \times \text{recruitment likelihood ratio} \times \text{pivot likelihood ratio}.$$

Interpretation: A voter does not condition only on her signal. She also learns from the fact that she was recruited and from the hypothetical event that her vote is pivotal. The pivot term is the nonstandard part.

4.4 Theorem 1: exogenous state-dependent participation

- If turnout is the same across states, information aggregation is guaranteed in the relevant large-election equilibria.
- If turnout is lower in α , additional equilibria exist in which policy a wins in both states.
- If turnout is lower in β , additional equilibria exist in which policy b wins in both states.

Interpretation: The policy associated with the low-turnout state can dominate because a pivotal voter infers that the low-turnout state is more likely.

4.5 Theorem 2: endogenous manipulation

- The organizer privately observes the state and chooses recruitment.
- As recruitment cost goes to zero, there are equilibria with many recruited voters in both states.
- The organizer recruits more in β than in α , which sustains voter beliefs that favor policy a .
- Policy a wins with probability converging to one in both states.

Interpretation: The organizer can turn the participation curse into a manipulation technology. The manipulation is self-confirming: expected low turnout in α makes voters favor a , and voters favoring a makes recruiting more in β optimal.

4.6 Theorem 3: all equilibria under small recruitment costs

- When recruitment costs vanish, no nontrivial equilibrium fully aggregates information.
- Equilibria either look like the fully manipulated equilibrium or have a special limit cutoff at the median signal in α .
- Even the special equilibria fail to implement the correct policy in both states with probability one.

Interpretation: The result strengthens the paper’s claim: manipulation is not merely a possible bad equilibrium; full aggregation disappears in the small-cost limit.

5 Mechanism and theoretical design

5.1 Participation curse

The central force is that a voter is pivotal when the other voters are split almost evenly. In a larger electorate, this event is rarer. Therefore, if voters expect fewer participants in α than in β , the event of being pivotal shifts posterior beliefs toward α . Since policy a is correct in α , pivotal voters may rationally vote for a even when their own signals are not strongly favorable to α .

Economic message: Being pivotal is itself a signal. In standard jury models it is neutral because turnout is state-independent. Here it is biased because turnout differs by state.

5.2 Why large elections can make manipulation easier

In large elections, small differences in vote shares are magnified into almost certain majority outcomes. Once the organizer induces individual voters to support a with probability just above one half in both states, majority rule turns that slight individual bias into near-certain implementation of a .

Economic message: The law of large numbers becomes a tool of manipulation: it amplifies a small pivot-induced bias into a nearly deterministic election outcome.

5.3 Why commitment is not required

The first part of the paper shows that any exogenous turnout imbalance can support nonaggregation. The second part then shows that an informed organizer can generate the relevant imbalance endogenously. The organizer does not need to commit publicly to turnout rules before observing the state; the equilibrium recruitment strategy itself creates the expected asymmetry.

Interpretation: This makes the result stronger than a simple commitment story. Manipulation can survive even when voters understand the organizer’s bias and infer from being recruited.

5.4 Robust design and competition

Unanimity-like rules can reduce the organizer's incentive to recruit selectively because one opposing vote can block the favored policy. Near-unanimity with a quorum can combine some information aggregation with protection against manipulation. Competition between two biased organizers can generate equilibria with information aggregation, but fully manipulated equilibria may remain.

Interpretation: Election design can partially repair the problem, but simple majority rule is vulnerable when turnout can be manipulated.

6 Figures, theorem panels, and equation panels

6.1 Equation Panel: Critical Likelihood Ratio and Lemma 1—posterior inference from signal, recruitment, and pivotality

For a given symmetric voter strategy d , the expected vote share for policy a in state ω is

$$q_\omega(d) := \Pr(d(s) = a | \omega) = \int_{s \in [0,1]} \mathbf{1}_{d(s)=a} f(s|\omega) ds.$$

The probability of being pivotal in state ω if the expected vote share is q_ω and the number of recruited voter pairs is n_ω is

$$\binom{2n_\omega}{n_\omega} (q_\omega)^{n_\omega} (1 - q_\omega)^{n_\omega}.$$

In our model, there is additional information contained in the event that a voter is recruited. This is because the probability of being recruited depends on the state of the world: the probability of being recruited in state ω if the number of recruited voter pairs is n_ω is

$$\frac{2n_\omega + 1}{N}.$$

Taken together, when all other voters are using strategy d and the organizer is using a pure strategy $\mathbf{n} = (n_\alpha, n_\beta)$, then the posterior likelihood ratio that the state is α , conditional on (1) receiving a signal s , (2) being recruited, and (3) being pivotal, is given by¹⁰

$$\Phi(s, \text{piv}, \text{rec}; \mathbf{n}, d) := \underbrace{\frac{\rho}{1-\rho}}_{\text{prior}} \underbrace{\frac{f(s|\alpha)}{f(s|\beta)}}_{\text{signal}} \underbrace{\frac{\frac{2n_\alpha+1}{N}}{\frac{2n_\beta+1}{N}}}_{\text{recruited}} \underbrace{\frac{\binom{2n_\alpha}{n_\alpha} (q_\alpha)^{n_\alpha} (1-q_\alpha)^{n_\alpha}}{\binom{2n_\beta}{n_\beta} (q_\beta)^{n_\beta} (1-q_\beta)^{n_\beta}}}_{\text{pivotal}}, \quad (4)$$

where we omit the dependence of q_ω on the voter strategy d for ease of reading.¹¹

This likelihood ratio, which we refer to as *the critical likelihood ratio*, guides a voter's decision. In particular, a voter having a signal s supports policy a if the critical likelihood ratio $\Phi(s, \text{piv}, \text{rec}; \mathbf{n}, d)$ is above 1, and supports policy b otherwise. From the MLRP condition from Assumption (1), Φ is strictly decreasing in s . Therefore, voters use cut-off strategies in all equilibria.¹²

Lemma 1 *Any equilibrium voting strategy has a cut-off structure. There is a signal $\hat{s}$ such that a recruited voter casts a vote for policy b if $s > \hat{s}$ and for policy a if $s < \hat{s}$.*

Equation panel: critical likelihood ratio and cutoff structure.

Read: The panel decomposes the posterior likelihood ratio into prior beliefs, the private-signal likelihood ratio, the recruitment likelihood ratio, and the pivotality likelihood ratio. Lemma 1 states that equilibrium voting strategies have a cutoff form.

Interpretation: The decomposition is the paper's core technical object. It shows that a pivotal voter does not evaluate only her signal; she also updates from the probability that she would have been recruited and pivotal in each state. The pivotality term is especially important because it changes exponentially with electorate size.

Economic message: Turnout affects beliefs. A voter can rationally overweight the state with fewer voters because that is where one vote is more likely to matter.

What not to over-read: The cutoff result does not imply voters are irrational or blindly following the organizer. They are Bayesian. The problem is that Bayesian inference from pivotality becomes distorted when participation is state-dependent.

6.2 Theorem 1: Large voting equilibria with state-dependent turnout

Theorem 1 Fix $\theta > 0$. Take a sequence of elections in which the number of voters is $\{n_\alpha^k, n_\beta^k\}_{k=1}^\infty$, with $n_\alpha^k = \theta n_\beta^k$ for all k , $n_\alpha^k \rightarrow \infty$, and $n_\beta^k \rightarrow \infty$.

1. For all $\theta > 0$, there exists a sequence of voting equilibria with limit cut-off $s^* \in (s_\alpha, s_\beta)$ that aggregates information.
For $\theta = 1$, there are no other limit outcomes of interior voting equilibria: information is always aggregated.
2. For all $\theta < 1$, there are additional sequences of voting equilibria with limit cut-off $s^* \in (s_\beta, 1)$ in which policy a wins in the limit in both states.
There are no other limit outcomes of interior voting equilibria: either information is aggregated or a wins in both states.
3. For all $\theta > 1$, there are additional sequences of voting equilibria with limit cut-off $s^* \in (0, s_\alpha)$ in which policy b wins in the limit in both states.
There are no other limit outcomes of interior voting equilibria: either information is aggregated or b wins in both states.

The basic intuition for the existence of additional equilibria is as described in Section 1 and

Theorem 1: information aggregation is guaranteed only when turnout is state-independent.

Read: The theorem states that when the ratio of voters across states is one, information is aggregated in all relevant large-election equilibria. If the ratio differs from one, additional equilibria exist in which the policy favored in the smaller-turnout state wins in both states.

Interpretation: This theorem is the first major departure from the standard Condorcet-jury benchmark. It does not say aggregation is impossible; it says aggregation is no longer guaranteed across all equilibria once turnout depends on the state.

Economic message: A state-dependent electorate can create a systematic bias in large elections. The low-turnout state becomes overrepresented in pivotal reasoning.

What not to over-read: The theorem is not primarily about small samples or finite-election noise. The failure persists asymptotically as the number of voters grows.

6.3 Figure 1: Probability that policy a receives the majority as a function of recruited voter pairs

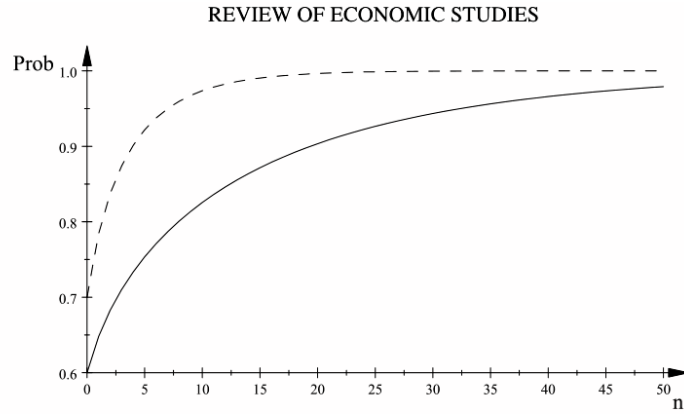


FIGURE 1
 probability that policy a receives the majority of votes given the number of recruited voter pairs n for $q_\beta = 0.6$ (solid line) and for $q_\alpha = 0.7$ (dashed). The curve is steeper for $q_\beta = 0.6$ when n is large, implying a larger marginal benefit from additional recruitment at larger n .

Figure 1: majority probability by number of recruited voter pairs for $q_\beta = 0.6$ and $q_\alpha = 0.7$.

Read: Both curves rise toward one as the number of recruited voter pairs increases. The dashed curve with the higher vote probability rises quickly. The lower curve is initially lower but has a larger marginal gain from additional recruitment at larger n .

Interpretation: The organizer's marginal benefit from adding voters depends on how close the current majority probability is to one. When policy a is already very likely to win in α but less likely in β , the marginal value of additional voters can be higher in β .

Economic message: The figure visualizes why the organizer may recruit more voters in the state where his preferred outcome is less secure. This recruitment difference then feeds back into voters' pivotality inference.

What not to over-read: The figure is an illustrative numerical picture, not an empirical estimate. Its role is to clarify the fixed-point logic behind the manipulated equilibrium.

6.4 Theorem 2: Manipulated electorates under endogenous recruitment

voters, and thus we can compare our result to those for exogenously large elections. To this end, we fix the common prior ρ and some information structure F that satisfies Assumptions (1) and (2). Let $\{G(c)\}_{c>0}$ be a collection of voting games in which, for each game $G(c)$, the prior belief is ρ , the information structure is F , the recruitment cost to the organizer is c , and the number of potential voters, $N(c)$, is some integer that satisfies Assumption (3).

Theorem 2 *Let $\{c_k\}_{k=1,2,\dots}$ be a sequence of positive numbers that converge to 0. Then, there is a sequence of symmetric Nash equilibria of $G(c_k)$ such that in both states:*

1. *The probability that policy a is implemented converges to 1.*
2. *The number of recruited voters increases without bound.*
3. *The organizer's payoff converges to 1.*

Theorem 2 states that, as the recruitment cost vanishes and the number of potential voters becomes large, there are equilibria in which policy a is elected with a probability that is arbitrarily close to 1 in *both* states. Moreover, in both states the number of recruited voters becomes large, and the organizer's expected payoff becomes 1. Thus, an endogenously large electorate may lead

Theorem 2: as recruitment costs vanish, manipulated equilibria implement policy a with probability approaching one.

Read: The theorem states that for recruitment costs approaching zero, there is a sequence of symmetric Nash equilibria in which policy a is implemented with probability approaching one in both states, the number of recruited voters grows without bound, and the organizer's payoff converges to one.

Interpretation: This result endogenizes the participation asymmetry of Theorem 1. The organizer chooses state-dependent recruitment after observing the state, and voters correctly anticipate this. The equilibrium is self-consistent: voters' behavior makes extra recruitment more valuable in β , and that recruitment pattern makes voters' pivot beliefs favor α .

Economic message: Manipulation does not require suppressing all information or deceiving voters about preferences. It can arise from changing who participates.

What not to over-read: The theorem establishes existence of manipulated equilibria. Later results characterize the full equilibrium set and show that full information aggregation fails more broadly when recruitment costs are small.

6.5 Theorem 3: All equilibria with endogenous recruitment and vanishing recruitment costs

additional voter in either state, for a sufficiently small c .³³ If the inequality fails, there is always a trivial equilibrium in which each voter supports policy a with a probability below $1/2$ in both states of the world, which justifies the organizer's strategy to recruit no additional voters.³⁴

Theorem 3 *Let $\{c_k\}_{k=1,2,\dots}$ be a sequence of positive numbers converging to 0 and $\{G(c_k)\}_{k=1,2,\dots}$ be the induced voting games.*

1. *For every limit cut-off s^* of nontrivial equilibria, either $s^* = s_\alpha$ or $s^* > s_\beta$. Therefore, information is never aggregated in the limit.*
2. *There exists a sequence of nontrivial equilibria with limit cut-off $s^* > s_\beta$ and another sequence with limit cut-off $s^* = s_\alpha$.*
3. *If inequality (11) holds, then along all nontrivial equilibrium sequences with limit cut-off $s^* = s_\alpha$,*

- *The number of recruited voters increases without bounds in state α and is 0 in state β .*
- *Policy a is implemented in state α with probability converging to 1 and with probability converging to $F(s_\alpha|\beta)$ in state β .*

The proof of the theorem is in the Appendix. The characterization of the set of all equilibrium outcomes may be the technically most demanding part of the analysis in the article.

To give a rough idea of the characterization of equilibria with limit cut-off s_α , note that, for a sequence of cut-offs with limit $c^* \in (c_\alpha, c_\beta)$, the pivotality probability would vanish at an

Theorem 3: full information aggregation disappears in the small-cost limit.

Read: The theorem characterizes limiting nontrivial equilibria as recruitment costs go to zero. Limit cutoffs are either at the α median or strictly above the β median. In neither case is information fully aggregated.

Interpretation: Theorem 3 is the paper's strongest equilibrium-selection message. Even if one worries that Theorem 2 only identifies one bad equilibrium, Theorem 3 says the limiting equilibrium set itself excludes full aggregation.

Economic message: Endogenous turnout manipulation is not an isolated pathology. Once the organizer can choose turnout cheaply, the information-aggregation property of majority rule is fundamentally fragile.

What not to over-read: The theorem is still within the model's assumptions: binary states, binary policies, common-interest voters, a single biased organizer, and unobserved turnout. It does not say every real election is manipulable in this exact way.

6.6 Design Panel: Robust election design, unanimity, and near-unanimity with a quorum

6.2. Robust election design

We explore whether election design can be a remedy for an organizer's ability to manipulate election outcomes by inducing asymmetric participation rates. To this end, we discuss a design based on the unanimity rule that provides protection against such manipulation.

6.2.1. Unanimity rule. We already observed that the unanimity rule can be beneficial with an exogenous asymmetry in participation. With endogenous participation, there is yet another potential benefit. As discussed before, suppose the outcome is a unless one or more voters support b (that is, unless there is a "veto" against it). It is immediate that, under this rule, the organizer recruits no additional voters. This is because an additional voter only changes the outcome if she submits a veto against the organizer's preferred outcome. As a consequence, with this rule, the organizer has no incentives to induce an asymmetric participation pattern. Also, even though just one voter chooses for all, her choice is still preferred by the voters to the fully manipulated equilibrium outcome from Theorem 2 in which the outcome is almost surely a .

6.2.2. Near unanimity with a quorum. The unanimity rule has two drawbacks. First, only the information from one voter is included because the organizer will cease recruitment. To remedy this, one may require the organizer to recruit a certain minimal number of voters; that is, to impose a quorum: the organizer has to recruit at least m additional pairs of voters, otherwise the outcome is b .

Second, as noted in the literature, unanimity is generally not a good rule for information aggregation. Intuitively, since one veto already decides the outcome, the outcome cannot reflect the information from much more than one signal.³⁵ To remedy this second problem, one may reduce the veto power and stipulate that some number $k(m)$ of vetoes are needed for b to win. So, "near unanimity with a quorum" stipulates that the outcome is b if the quorum m fails or more than $k(m)$ vetoes are submitted; otherwise, the outcome is a .³⁶ Informally, the organizer is required to ask the opinion of at least m agents, and of those, not more than $k(m)$ must be against his preferred alternative. A result by Chakraborty and Ghosh (2003) implies that, with this rule, information is fully aggregated if and only if $m - k(m)$ and m both grow to infinity.³⁷

In practice, many decisions by committees require a quorum in order to ensure that a certain

Design panel: unanimity and near-unanimity as safeguards against turnout manipulation.

Read: The panel discusses unanimity and near-unanimity rules with a quorum as ways to reduce manipulation. Under unanimity, one dissenting voter can block the organizer's preferred outcome, reducing the value of additional recruitment.

Interpretation: Majority rule is vulnerable because a small individual voting bias is amplified by the law of large numbers. Unanimity-like rules change the organizer's payoff from recruitment: adding voters increases the chance that at least one voter vetoes.

Economic message: Election design can change the incentives for turnout manipulation. Quorum and veto-like rules can be useful when the organizer controls participation.

What not to over-read: Unanimity is not a universal solution. It may aggregate little information and can create veto-player problems. The paper's lesson is that robust design must account for turnout incentives, not that unanimity is always optimal.

7 Short summary

- The paper studies information aggregation in elections when turnout can depend on the state.
- Voters have common interests and want the policy that matches the state.
- A biased organizer observes the state and wants policy a regardless of the state.

- Voters receive private signals and do not observe turnout.
- With exogenous turnout, any asymmetry in turnout across states creates nonaggregating equilibria in large elections.
- The mechanism is the participation curse: pivotality is more likely in the state with fewer voters.
- With endogenous recruitment, the organizer can create state-dependent turnout after observing the state.
- As recruitment costs fall, manipulated equilibria implement the organizer’s favorite policy with probability approaching one.
- The full equilibrium characterization shows that information aggregation fails in all nontrivial limiting equilibria when recruitment costs vanish.
- The paper’s incremental contribution is to identify state-dependent participation as a fundamental vulnerability of majority-rule information aggregation.
- Robust design may require quorum or near-unanimity rules, or competition among organizers with opposing biases.

8 Expanded conclusion

8.1 Core conclusion

Ekmekci and Lauermann show that large elections are not automatically reliable information aggregators. The standard Condorcet logic works when the number of voters is independent of the state, but it can fail when turnout varies with the state. Because a vote is more likely to be pivotal in a smaller electorate, voters who condition on being pivotal systematically overweight the low-turnout state. This can make one policy win in both states, even when all voters share common interests and receive informative signals.

8.2 Why the result matters

The result matters because turnout is rarely a neutral object. In real political and organizational settings, turnout can be influenced by campaign mobilization, meeting design, agenda timing, disclosure rules, transportation, reminders, and administrative frictions. The paper shows that these participation choices can affect not only who votes but also what information the election aggregates.

8.3 Incremental contribution in one paragraph

The paper’s main incremental contribution is to connect state-dependent participation to the failure of information aggregation and then to endogenize that participation through a biased organizer. Earlier large-election models emphasized that majority rule aggregates dispersed signals. This paper shows that the conclusion is not robust to endogenous or state-dependent turnout. Earlier uncertain-electorate models showed that aggregating equilibria can exist; this paper shows that nonaggregating equilibria exist and that, with endogenous recruitment, full aggregation can disappear.

8.4 Mechanism intuition

The mechanism is subtle because voters are fully rational. A recruited voter knows the organizer may have manipulated turnout. She also knows that her vote matters only when the election is close. If turnout is expected to be lower in α , then being pivotal is stronger evidence that α is true. Thus, even a voter with a moderately β -favoring signal may vote for a because the pivotal event changes her posterior. The organizer exploits exactly this inference.

8.5 Policy and design implications

The paper suggests that election rules should be evaluated not only by their aggregation properties under fixed participation but also by their robustness to participation manipulation. Majority rule is attractive when participation is exogenous and balanced, but it is vulnerable when one actor can influence turnout. Quorum requirements, near-unanimity rules, public information about turnout, and competition among organizers can reduce manipulation, though each introduces its own tradeoffs.

8.6 Final takeaway

The enduring lesson is that information aggregation is a joint property of voting rules, signals, and participation. Large numbers of voters do not by themselves guarantee correct decisions. If the process determining who votes is state-dependent and strategically influenced, then the electoral mechanism can aggregate the wrong information or amplify a manipulated bias.